As we spoke, I was amazed by the scope of his knowledge. It was a far cry from the demeaning and willful image of Pappu that was thrust upon him. I found him to be well informed as we conversed about various issues, both national and international. I wondered how much money and energy must have gone into the BJP's pet project of wrongfully projecting him as an ignorant politician.

Meanwhile, my daughter Iltija was holding on to his arm, utterly besotted. I smiled to myself. RG had managed to charm all the three generations effortlessly. We were so deeply engrossed in our conversation that three hours of walking 15 kilometres flew by in an instant.

The sudden outpouring and spontaneous participation of thousands of people who joined us also had a lot to do with the growing alienation and suffocation that's engulfed Jammu and Kashmir after the abrogation of Article 370.

The BJP's blunder of severing the only constitutional link between Jammu and Kashmir and the country has ensured that an entire apparatus has been deployed to cover the grim consequences of their actions. The only communication the government of India has had is through weaponized agencies such as the Enforcement Directorate, the National Investigation Agency, the Central Bureau of Investigation and the use of draconian laws such as the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act and the Public Safety Act.[1] Fear, intimidation and suppression have become their preferred modus operandi. From the common man to journalists to politicians, no one is spared. Anyone who dares to go against their false narrative is hounded. Most of the business houses in Jammu and Kashmir have been raided time and again to drive home the point that this government wants to crush the people of Jammu and Kashmir in every way possible—politically, economically and even socially. The attempts to dilute our collective heritage and identity cannot be overlooked.

During the course of my conversation with RG, Jammu came up. A wrong impression that the people of Jammu are jubilant and have benefited after the 2019 constitutional hara-kiri couldn't be further from the truth. Jammu, being a commercial hub, has suffered tremendously.